

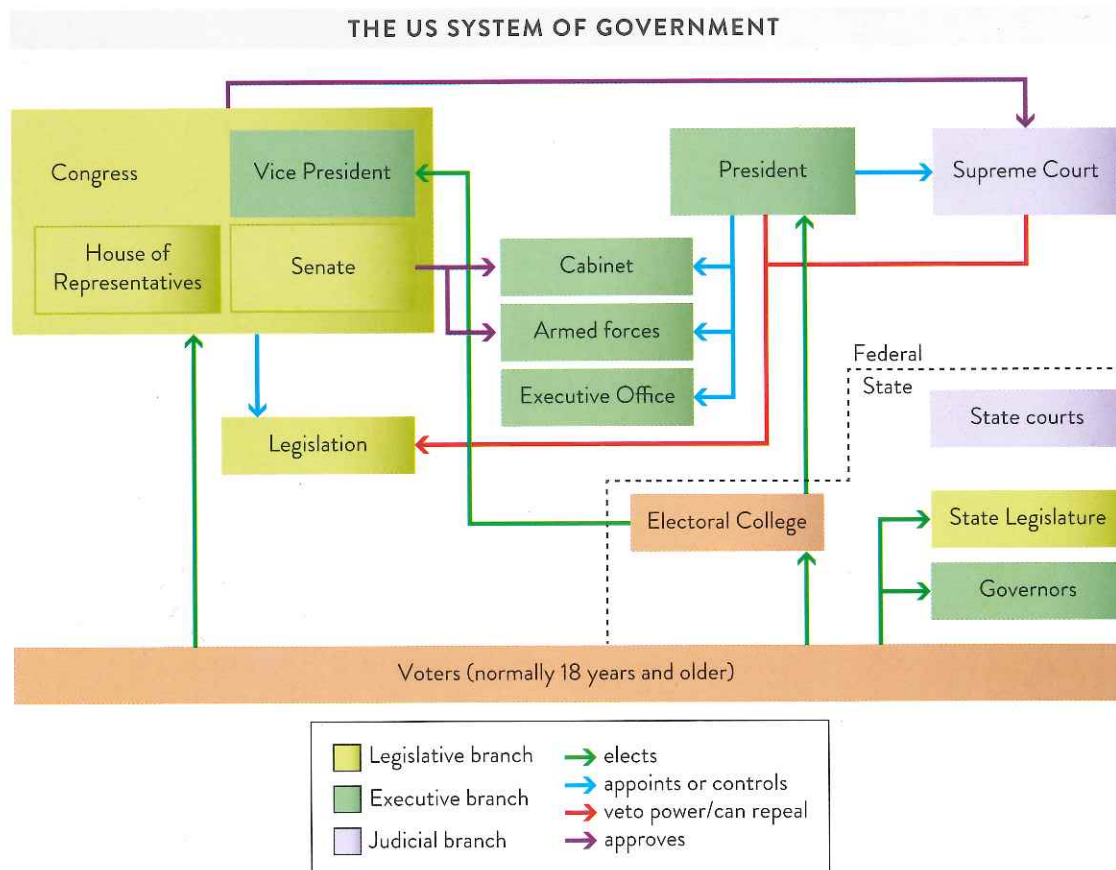
Free and united

In 1775, 13 colonies on the eastern seaboard of North America declared their independence from Great Britain. The American Revolution, and the War of Independence that followed, took place between 1775 and 1783. Britain was defeated and the former British colonies became free and independent in 1783. The shape of the new nation was defined in its Constitution, which laid out the system and structures of the government of the United States of America. The Constitution came into effect in 1789.

In the following decades, America would expand westwards, taking over Native American land through war and forced removal. New territories were established, and America also acquired former British, French and Spanish territories in the west. Territories became states when the settler population was large enough to support a state government, and the majority of those eligible to vote supported statehood.

The American population quadrupled between 1820 and 1860, and by the end of the 19th century, the country stretched from the Atlantic seaboard to the Pacific Ocean. By the mid-1800s, the United States had developed into a global sea power.

America's wealth also came through agricultural production and whaling. The prospect of free land and new opportunities drew migrants to the west, into the new territories. This expansion supported the idea that America would be an agrarian society made up of independent, landowning (yeoman) farmers, unlike Europe, where society was considered



SOURCE 1.1 The US system of government